

Alchemy is so misunderstood that to say the Harry Potter books are built on alchemical structures and imagery is, to many readers, not much different from saying the books aren't worth reading or that they are dangerous to read.

One of the first lessons in chemistry class is that it grew out of the pseudoscience, alchemy whose goal was to create the "philosopher's stone" that could turn lead into gold and bestow immortality on the alchemist.

What alchemy is really about is turning something common into something special. It was about a spiritual path within the revealed religions to return fallen man to his Edenic perfection. Rowling uses alchemy in Harry Potter as a metaphor for change and as a resource for powerful imagery.

All the great writers, to some degree, use alchemical imagery. Shakespeare's plays are written on alchemical themes. In a proper tragedy, the audience identifies with the hero in his/her agony and shares in their passion. the audience experiences their "hero's journey" and are 'purified' along with the actors on stage or in a book.

The idea that reading was entertainment and diversion is a new idea, actually only the past 70 or 80 years. The rule in traditional cultures, and even in cultures such as ours, is that stories, in whatever form, are meant to instruct and change us.

What is Alchemy?

Before getting into how Rowling uses alchemy I want to first explain where it comes from and what it is.

This whole tradition, including alchemy, comes from Egypt and is known as the Hermetic tradition. It includes, not only alchemy, but numerology, gnosticism and even astrology.

From Egypt there have survived 18 tractates generally known as the corpus Hermeticum. These scriptures of a small, mystic sect which honored the Egyptian God Thoth identified with the Greek god Hermes, under the title Trismegistos' or 'thrice greatest'. They date from the 1st cent. AD and bring together wisdom from Egypt, Greece and Asia.

All are concerned to declare a divine revelation. Initiation begins with a call to repentance: Then comes personal instruction so the initiate was required to turn away from ignorance, grief, intemperance, sensuality, injustice, avarice, folly, envy, deceit, anger, impetuosity and malice and embrace knowledge of God with joy, self-control, continence, righteousness, generosity, truth, goodness, life and light.

This involved ascetic discipline and self-discipline.

From this the initiate passed to silent meditation in solitude and then the climax was an ecstatic vision of LIGHT, delightful and joyous. This light is described as "the first God" and this knowledge of god is the human's salvation. by this alone can a soul become good. It is a re-birth and a sense of identity with all creation, Earth, air, fire and water, as well as plants and animals. More, it is to enter into God.

ALCHEMY, wrote Pierre-Jean Fabre in 1636, is not merely an art or science to teach metallic translations, so much as a true and solid science that teaches how to know the center of all things, which in the divine language is called the Spirit of Life."

Essential to alchemy is the understanding of "correspondences" between the material and the spiritual. "As above, so below."

Thus the alchemist was seeking under suitable astrological conditions to bring together primary matter and the primary agent (also called secret fire.)

First, to produce a pure mercurial substance, then an incombustible sulphur and finally the 'philosopher's stone', which had the power of transmuting base metals into gold, but whose discovery was also a necessary part of the realization of the human's full faculties, and a precondition of the discovery of the panacea, the elixir of life, which would transmute the human body into an incorporeal body of light, so securing for the Adept omniscience, omnipotence and the joy of divine love.

Thus, the human being is the true subject of the alchemist's art. The three principles, Sulphur of his earthly part, Salt of the intellect and above all, Mercury, the mercury of the wise, "snowy splendour", the spark of the soul, the mystical spirit, must be brought together in the Azoth or Philosopher's Egg set within the Cauldron, which is the human itself.

This is done by the fire of love. Then the transmutation of natural into spiritual human may begin.

The first stage of the process is Blackness, the stage of purgation

The second stage is whiteness, the stage of illumination

the third stage, or climax, is redness, the color of alchemical gold, and is also called the marriage of Luna and Sol, the human and the divine, the finite with the infinite

There are many books, including "Lord of the Rings", that are designed to trigger a powerful experience but the difference is that Rowling uses these images and symbols extensively and deliberately to great effect. She even talks about it in a 1998 interview. She says:

"I've never wanted to be a witch, but an alchemist.To invent this wizard world, I've learned a ridiculous amount about alchemy. . . .I have to know in detail what magic can and cannot do in order to set the parameters and establish the stories' internal logic."

Alchemy appears everywhere in HP. In book titles, the first book was called Harry Potter and the Philosopher's stone but an American editor didn't think the word philosophy in the title would sell so changed it for American audiences to "sorcerer's stone". This obscured the main point of Rowling's plan and created a real problem with right wing Christian's.

the characters are alchemical. Albus Dumbledore is an alchemist of renown and a partner to a real famous alchemist, Nicolas Flamel, who was an actual famous alchemist who lived in 14th century Paris. Hermione Granger's name is the feminine form of Hermes, who, besides being the

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messenger of the gods, was also the name of the great alchemist Hermes Trismegistos, in whose name countless alchemical works were written thru the centuries. Even Harry's father, James, was named for the patron saint of alchemists and his mother, Lily, a symbol for the second purifying stage of the alchemical work.

AS we have already discussed, The alchemical work is about changing the soul from lead to gold, from failing to virtue. This is evident in each book in Harry's transformations that take place in each book.

In Philosopher's stone the orphaned Harry lives in fear of his aunt and uncle w/o any knowledge of who he is. By the books end, he shows himself a champion of remarkable courage and has become reconciled to his parents death and to his own destiny as a wizard.

In Chamber of Secrets he begins the book as a prisoner of the Dursleys and his own self-doubts and self pity. At the heroic finish, he risks his own life to liberate Ginny (read Virgin) and vanquish the villain who is an incarnation of selfishness and self-importance.

In Prisoner of Azkaban he begins by blowing up his Aunt Marge in anger. In the end, he rescues the man who betrayed his parents to Voldemort by offering his own life as a shield to him. He goes from unforgiving judgment to selfless mercy in a year in the 3rd book.

In Goblet of Fire he is initially consumed by worry of what others think of him and by books end, after trials with his best friend, a dragon, and other problems, he is able to shrug off a front-page hatchet job in wizarding world's main newspaper, "the Daily Prophet".

In The Order of the Phoenix, Harry is consumed by a desire for news from anywhere. At the end, he is aware of his need to turn inward and to discover and strengthen his inner life. He knows that his dependence on the outer world and its events was his point of vulnerability which Voldemort used to manipulate him and that this weakness caused his godfathers death.

When Harry comes onto the scene in Half-blood prince, he is half asleep as he waits for Dumbledore to come for him. He is even worried about Dumbledore's concern for him. by the end he is ready to take on the mission that Dumbledore has given him even tho the headmaster is dead.

As with the hero's journey finale in Deathly Hallows, Harry's alchemical transformation in that book is the stunning ending to which all previous transformations turned out to be only pointers or foreshadowing.

At books beginning, Harry's faith in Dumbledore is all but broken by Rita Skeeter's revelations about him. Harry chooses to believe in Dumbledore. After Dobby's death, despite his doubts and what he has learned, Harry realizes that the search for horcruxes which will bring Lord Voldemort's special protection from death to an end is his goal rather than the power of the deathly hallows. This empowers Harry's great change into the "Christ" figure who rises from King's Cross after being 'killed' by Voldemort.

Harry's final transformation from doubter to believer and to vanquisher of both his internal failings and the external evil of Voldemort completes the seven stage alchemical work.

The design of each of the books parallels the alchemical work. Harry's two closest friends, Ron, the redheaded passionate boy and Hermione Granger, the brilliant, cool young woman. Ron represents sulfur and Hermione (HG = symbol for) mercury. Harry's friendships with these two transform him from lead into gold. Sulfur and Mercury are often called the "quarreling couple" an apt idea for Ron and Hermione.

We have already discussed the hero's journey in each book but each book also mirrors the alchemical transformation, the three stages, of the journey.

Characters are named for these stages. the first stage, called the nigredo, or black stage. the book, Order of the Pheonix, is the black stage of the whole series and Sirius Black is the featured and it ends with his death.

The second stage is purification, usually called the albedo or white work. When matter reaches this stage it has become pure and spotless, brilliant white. Albus Dumbledore (Albus, is latin for White) is named for this stage. Other symbols for this stage include the moon (Luna, one of Harry's friends), and a lily, the name of his mother. This book, The Half Blood Prince, ends with Dumbledore's death.

The last stage is the reongealing or perfection called the red stage. Rubeus (latin for red) Hagrid is named for this stage. The red lion is the symbol. Deathly Hollows is the big crucible finish to the series. Rubeus Hagrid doesn't die but Fred Weasley, a red head, does as do many others in the battle.

Each of the books in the series follows the alchemical three stages. The black work is the work done in Harry at the Dursley's and in Hogwarts classroom by Snape, the teacher that seems to hate him.

The white work, or purification occurs under the watchful eye of Albus Dumbledore during Harry's time at Hogwarts.

The red work is always in the climactic scene and is always underground or in a graveyard, in which Harry dies a figurative death and is saved by love in the presence of some Christological symbol.

The resurrection at story's end each year is the culmination of that year's cycle and transformation. The cycle closes with congratulations and explanations from the master alchemist, Dumbledore, and a return to the Dursleys for another trip thru the cycle. Of course, the last book ends with Harry actually dying and rising and ends his journey to perfection.

CONCLUSION:

The reason good authors use these alchemical images is because the three stages of the alchemical process and the whole "Great Work" of alchemy parallels the spiritual stages of transformation common to all the world's great religions.

Great writers in the English tradition have used alchemical imagery from the 16th to the present century because it works in grabbing hold of the readers hearts and bringing them to the imaginative place of transformation.

a big piece of this world wide phenomenon springs from people's individual and collective response, largely unconscious, to Rowling's traditional alchemical artistry and the spiritual message it carries.

THEMES IN HARRY POTTER

How do you decide if a book is worth reading? In these books we find the answer to four principal questions.

- *How are we to treat one another?
- *What is the answer to the mystery of death?
- *When are we to embrace change or flee change?
- *What makes a human being good or bad, or even human?

In the Harry Potter books it is prejudice that is the problem. In this regard these are not "kids books." The message of HP is clear: poisonous prejudice is everywhere, and only constant vigilance and resistance to the regime of ideas (whose government and media authorities foster and codify this hatred) will free us of it.

The HP books encourage readers to take a step back from the world and recognize what an unloving place it is. This step back is the first necessary step to any spiritual life. The ladder of divine ascent in every revealed tradition requires recognizing the fallen world for what it is.

It is in Order of the phoenix we find out how inbred and insular the leading magical families have become over the generations and how their narrow belief in eugenics or 'good breeding' have taken them into the dark lords service. Thus, they have divided their world into pure breeds and mudbloods, those who are witches but are not pure. These have muggle, ie human, parents. Hermione Granger is one of these. It is the same thinking that created Nazi camps and soviet gulags.

What all these characters learn is that none are either all good or all bad. The revelation for her is that we readers are the prejudiced ones. Every novel ends with a surprise that all were not what they seemed.

These books are read and re-read because they offer the right answer. That answer is LOVE. prejudice is a failure in love. We recognize in these stories the desire to see what makes us feel best about ourselves even if it means being unkind or dismissive of others.

Harry has to overcome his prejudice of Severus Snape and accept that it was Severus love for Harry's mother, Lily, that has kept him alive all these years. Harry was able to sacrifice himself in love for his friends because he has the darkness within himself.

That love as the solution to prejudice so dominates the story line of all these books makes it in the tradition of the Inklings, and Christian literature in general.

DEATH AS HER MAIN THEME.

Rowling lost her mother to MS in 1990, the same year she conceived of the Harry Potter books. She said, "In fact, death and bereavement and what death means. . . is one of the central themes of all seven books."

Every book develops the theme of love trumping death. However, it is in the first book that she has Dumbledore explain about love and death.

"your mother died to save you. If there is one thing Voldemort cannot understand, it is love. He didn't realize that love as powerful as your mother's for you leaves its own mark. Not a scar, no visible sign. . . to have been loved so deeply even tho the person who loved us is gone, will give

us some protection forever. It is in your very skin. Quirrell, full of hatred, greed and ambition, sharing his soul with Voldemort, could not touch you for this reason. It was agony to touch a person marked by something so good."

Thus, in the opening book, Philosopher's Stone, Rowling offers explicit teaching of what death is and the importance of the love of those departed that continues to protect us even in their absence. Especially when this love was a sacrificial love.

This is the major difference between Voldemort and Harry. Voldemort, fearing death pursues personal immortality by putting parts of his own soul into physical objects so if he dies, he still continues to live. These Horcruxes have been created by killing people. this separates him from any love of others as he invests in material things to survive. Fleeing human death, Voldemort becomes its nonliving, inhuman incarnation.

In contrast, when given Dumbledore's choice between what is good and what is easy, Harry always chooses the good even tho it means the probable loss of his physical life. He does so at the moment of crises in every book.

The war between the forces of good and evil that defines the final three novels of the series is largely between those who think physical life (existence) and advantage or power are the greatest goods and those who think what gives life meaning (the soul's ability to lov and laugh) is more real and important than just what is visible.

So, Rowling is saying that physical death is not the greatest evil but living a soulless existence in fear of death is the true death of the human spirit and the greater evil.

Thus, Harry in the final book, when Severus Snapes memories reveal that he must die if Voldemort is to be defeated and that he must die without fighting back. Harry walks into the forbidden Forest and lays down his life voluntarily accompanied by his mother and father.

Thus, Harry understood what Dumbledore had been trying to tell him. The difference between being dragged into battle to face death and walking into the arena with head held high.

To defeat the dark lord Harry has to transcend his ego concerns, even his inherited prejudices and doubts. That is, He has a destiny but his freewill choices are what will make the difference between his realizing his prophesied end or not.

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and spiritual quality of some other fantasy books, it is necessary to ask about the reasons for the presence of religious ideology within the structures of the fantastic.

Religious ideology within the structures of fantasy

The creation of a fantasy narrative rests upon the author's imagination, so it is true that the worlds and creatures depicted by fantasy are alive only thanks to the language – outside the pages of a book (and outside human imagination) they simply do not exist. But this does not mean that everything in fantasy literature is fleeting, ephemeral, and devoid of significance for the real world. The fantasy genre uses its own fantastic devices (witches, dragons, elves, kings, magic, etc.) to comment on real-world issues such as love and loss, joy and despair, freedom and oppression, life and death. As Richard Mathews puts it, fantasy literature is "a literature of liberation and subversion. Its target may be politics, economics, religion, psychology, or sexuality. It seeks to liberate the feminine, the unconscious, the repressed, the past, the present, and the future" (Mathews 2002: xii). In other words, writers use the structures of fantasy literature – just as any other type of literature – to express their comments on all of these (and other) topics, including religion.

One reason why religious themes and motifs so frequently appear in fantasy literature is because the genre greatly relies on the world's mythological heritage. Myths from around the world have long been a source of inspiration and a repository of ideas for writers of fantasy who indiscriminately use the various fantastic images and themes. Certain mythic patterns have even become standard within the structures of fantasy, e.g. the cosmic struggle

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between good and evil, the figure of a savior, the rites of passage, and the pattern of the hero's quest, called by Joseph Campbell 'the monomyth' (in *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*). Writers of fantasy do not purge these borrowed themes and images of religious/spiritual significance and that is one of the ways by which fantasy fiction is saturated with religious issues. For instance, the cosmic struggle between good and evil requires the presence of gods or other divine figures to form the basis for such a conflict, and an array of heroes that will have to choose sides and who are, as a result, entangled in a web of serious moral choices. The conflict frequently requires a savior figure, i.e. someone to suffer and sacrifice himself for the benefit of the community; this savior figure can be easily related to various myths and religions of the world, including Christianity. The rites of passage are also spiritually significant: they prepare the hero for a particular challenge, make him/her a member of the community, and grant him/her the extraordinary power and wisdom that brings the hero closer to the sphere of otherworldly events. A quest fraught with several dangers and challenges is usually one of the driving themes of a fantasy novel. The quest's stages are often those identified by Campbell within various myths and are also related to otherworldly issues: the hero frequently encounters gods and goddesses, enters a land of the dead, and even undergoes the process of divinization before (s)he is able to achieve the final goal. The monomyth is in essence the journey of one's spiritual transformation. Whether authors of fantasy incorporate the monomyth and other mythological elements into their stories consciously or not, the patterns have been used so frequently that at time the works based on them tend to be formulaic and even predictable. But this is only one of the dangers of having fantasy literature rely on mythological heritage. Scholars of the genre have observed that fantasy has granted itself the right to transform and adapt mythological material according to its own needs – a process which might be beneficial for fantasy, but not entirely so for the mythological traditions (see Attebery 2007, Tröcher 2009).

Furthermore, fantasy fiction is filled with religious ideas because the genre has inherited from mythology not only its various themes and images, but also the sphere of *sacrum* (Latin "sacred"). The spheres of *sacrum* and *profanum* (the sphere devoid of religious entities and manifestations) within mythologies has been extensively studied by Mircea Eliade who, in his research, points out that together with rites, ceremonies, religious symbols and activities, myths once allowed people to preserve their sacred beliefs (Eliade 2008). In contrast to their ancestors, modern people have changed (or blurred) the boundaries between their own sacred and profane spheres to the point that they have created (or attempted to create) for themselves a desacralized world (Eliade 2008: 9-14). Nevertheless, Eliade claims that elements of *sacrum* can be preserved unconsciously even in such a desacralized world, for instance, in the celebration of birth, marriage, and the New Year (2008: 100-103; 220-232; 2009a: 20-23). Moreover, Eliade has no doubts about the presence of *sacrum* within the boundaries of art, including contemporary books and movies (2008: 222-223). Eliade acknowledges the fact that the form of a myth can be transformed or even corrupted when the myth becomes part of a new medium of expression, but he argues that despite such distortion (and degradation), the core message of the myth might still be preserved and transmitted thanks to the new form (2009b: 15-17). As a result, fantasy literature, which greatly relies on mythological heritage, can also be treated as one of those modern forms that preserve the *sacrum* once found in mythology. The growing readership of fantasy and its recognition among academics can be treated as a sign that modern people, who have surrounded themselves with high-tech devices, still want to read about good winning over evil, still want to experience the marvelous and other-worldly, and still want to find spiritual sustenance (the forgotten or dismissed *sacrum*).

Fantasy literature can fulfill the above-mentioned expectations and address religious issues in a few ways. Firstly, authors of fantasy invent their own secondary-religions (frequently derived from religions existing in the real world)

Lewis's SPACE TRILOGY sets aside the traditional frameworks for allegory in favor of fantasy or Science fiction (depending on what one may think it is). He says in 1955 looking back upon earlier years, "The Idea of other planets exercised upon me then a peculiar, heady attraction, which was quite different from any other of my literary interests. . . .

The interest, when the fit was upon me, was ravenous, like a lust. . . . I may perhaps add that my own planetary romances have been not so much the gratification of that fierce curiosity as its exorcism. The exorcism worked by reconciling it with, or subjecting it to, the other, the more elusive, and genuinely imaginative, impulse."

OUT OF THE SILENT PLANET:

Out of the Silent Planet was written in 1938 and is the first volume in Lewis's so called "space trilogy" Whether it is science fiction or fantasy is something still debated. I am going to treat it, and the next two, as fantasy.

Dr. Elwin Ransom is the hero of all three of his "space trilogy" books. He is later renamed the Fisher King and partially modeled on J.R.R. Tolkien and Owen Barfield. He was a philologist of Cambridge University. Much like C.S. Lewis himself he was a bachelor, had a war wound, and was a "sedentary scholar". One of his publications was *Dialect and Semantics*.

Swimming was the only sport he excelled in, which came in handy in the second book. He combined heroic and intellectual qualities, though tended to put himself down. It has been said that he talked like C.S. Lewis himself.

Ransom, in the first novel, is kidnapped while on a walking holiday in the midlands (of England) and taken to a planet called Malacandra by its inhabitants,

but it is Mars to us. The two abductors, Devine and Weston (named for a famous physicist and materialist) who are under the misapprehension that the unseen ruler of Malacandra wants a human sacrifice--a fantasy created by their dark minds.

After escaping his captors, Ransom is at first terrified and disoriented by the red planet and its diversity of terrain and inhabitants--various forms of rational life related in a harmonious heirarchy.

The inhabitants,--the Sorns, the hrossa and the pfifltriggi--turn out to be civilized and amiable.

The, SORNS or SERONI had long thin legs, top heavy bodies, and thin faces with long, drooping noses and mouths. They were three times taller than the earhtman, Ransom. Sorns had scientific interests including cosmology and astronomy, and enjoyed metaphysical speculation. Ransom discovered, in response to their eager probing, that his own knowledge of Earth's geography, history and science was extremely sketchy.

The HROSSA were also sentient, intelligent beings who looked like gleaming black animals, a little like otters or seals, and yet are walking land creatures. From the Hrossa ransom Learns the languageof Old Solar. They are practical food gathering beings with a penchant for poetry.

The last sentient beings on Mars were the PFIFLTRIGGI who were froglike creatures and were crafts beings and engineers of the planet. They were expert in digging Malacandra's abundant gold and making artistic objects from it. They also recorded history and mythology of their planet.

The first beings Ransom meets are the Hrossa. Their lore provides material for satirical references to such unnatural conditions on earth as war, incontinence and adultery, social injustice and atheism.

More of the same comes by way of the Sorns. They express astonishment at what is told them of human history--of war, slavery, and prostitution. When Ransom is permitted to look at his world (which they call Thulcandra, the "silent planet") through their equivalent of a telescope, it is "the bleakest moment in all his travels."

The mythic possibilities of fantasy are also put to use. Malacandra is ruled by the Oyarsa, aided by innumerable Eldils. Eldils are something like Aquinas' notion of angels ("the body of an eldil is a movement swift as light"). Over all of them, creator and ruler of the whole universe in fact, is MALELDIL the young, a spiritual being who "lives with the Old One".

At Meldilorn, where he has been taken by one of the Sorns, Ransom meets the Oyarsa and learns more. Thulcandra (Earth) has been a silent planet, he is told, since it was spoiled by the Bent Oyarsa ("bent" is their metaphor for evil), but it has been besieged by Maleldil. The prophecies are that the siege of Thulcandra may be near its end.

Weston, and the forces behind Weston are the enemy, during these days near the end; and the "dangers to be feared are not planetary but cosmic, or at least solar, and they are not temporal but eternal."

Weston represents the kind of fusion of life-force philosophy and technological imperialism which for Lewis was the worst manifestation of scientism. In the myth Weston stands for the modern pride which, not being satisfied with what humanity has done to its own world, now wishes to make the interplanetary leap.

Lewis' most devastating satire comes when Weston stands before the Oyarsa, explaining the life-force ideology by which he justifies his galactic imperialism. Ransom, having learned the language, interprets for him, and what sounds fairly impressive in Weston's euphemistic jargon becomes brutal and ruthless in Malacandrian terms.

Although the names used are Maleldil and Oyarsa, Lewis is clearly presenting a cosmology and an understanding of God and man analogous to those of traditional Christian belief. Maleldil, Ransom realizes, is "a spirit w/o body, parts, or passions".

The Eldils are angels, the Oyarsa an archangel. The Oyarsa tells Ransom that, altho they are in many ways unlike, they are both "copies of Maleldil."

Bent as the term for evil suggests Augustines use of the world Curvatus as sin that moves a man to turn from god.

Lewis was angry at the science fiction of his time, which invariably portrayed extraterrestrial beings as evil, as the enemies of mankind. The medieval picture was exactly the reverse, and this appealed to Lewis. His reversal of the trend had a profound impact that has lasted to this day.

Within the story itself Ransom is made to state Lewis' own understanding of "pagan" myth in relation to reality: "It had dawned on him that the recurrent human tradition of bright, elusive people might after all have another explanation than the anthropologists had yet given", . . . "that the distinction between history and mythology might be itself meaningless outside the Earth."

This book is fictional apologetic but not explicitly Christian. Ransom knows on his return to Earth that the account is to be set forth not as "total explanation myth" but more as preperation. In Ransom's words":

What we need for the moment is not so much a body of belief as a body of people familiarized with certain ideas. If we could even effect in one per cent of our readers a change over from the conception of Space to the conception of Heaven, we should have made a beginning."

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PERELANDRA: (Voyage to Venus) 1943, is a paradisaal, oceanic world of floating islands as well as fixed lands. The ecology is un-fallen and includes the communion between the Green Lady and her husband and the animal and fish life of the planet, and is intended to contrast with the havoc of sin upon our world. It is a vision of perfection where natural and spiritual are one.

In *Perelandra* Lewis moves further in the direction of myth-making. Ransom has been commissioned to go to *Perelandra* (Venus) and help repel some sort of attack by the Bent Oyarsa. He is placed inside some sort of casket and whisked away, with no technological problem at all (I said it is fantasy).

Perelandra is the story of a second Eve in another paradise. Paradise retained could be another title. *Out of the Silent Planet* can now be seen as a mythical exposition of the created order and the possibility of its perversion by evil (Gen. 1-2 or *Paradise Lost* books 1-8)

Perelandra gives the account of the temptation. The fall that almost takes place is made the occasion for a celebration of the greatness of the redemption that came to our fallen world. The Christian significance is explicit in this story. Facing Professor Weston, who has made himself the instrument of evil, Ransom is made to say: "I'm a Christian."

MALELDIL is specifically spoken of as having become incarnate on Earth. Much of the didactic content is incorporated in two long theological disputes between Ransom, speaking for Theism, and Weston, with his pantheistic, emergent-evolution, life-spirit ideology.

The account of the temptation follows Milton's version of the Genesis story. The Lady is unfallen, humankind in Eden. She is both goddess and madonna, so that in her presence Ransom feels a sense of shame over his somewhat ugly body. She knows no evil and lives in fellowship with the beasts and in direct communion

with, and perfect obedience to, Maleldil, from whom she receives from time to time such knowledge as she needs.

Through Ransom she becomes aware for the first time of her freedom as she says:

"I thought that I was carried in the will of Him I love, but now I see that I walk with it."

She informs him of the one prohibition: she lives on the islands, the floating lands which undulate with the waves; she is not to dwell on the Fixed land. The image operates to suggest the contrast between living by faith and seeking a rigid kind of security.

Weston arrives by conventional space ship and initiates the ordeal by encouraging her to think about the fixed land, thus emphasizing the contrast between what is and what might be.

Next comes the appeal to her desire for wisdom (which she calls "growing older"). Finally, Weston urges her to exercise a kind of tragic courage. The commandment, he tells her, is a test, one which she can meet only by disobeying, by daring to be other than what she was created.

Her capacity for self-consciousness, good in itself, is being made an avenue for temptation, so that it will produce bad self-awareness, egotism, and idolatry.

Lewis incorporates other mythology in this story. When Ransom first awakes he sees a Dragon and the Lady seems to him to be Artemis as well as Eve and the madonna. The relation of myth to reality is again brought up: "were all the things which appeared as mythology on earth scattered through other worlds as realities?"

Lewis seems to indicate that the division of truth from myth and of both from fact were purely terrestrial, a result of the fall which separated soul and body.

Lewis own notion of temptation for modern man is represented in Weston who represents Scientism, a modern manifestation of pride and contemporary venture toward the false infinite and self deification. Weston becomes an archtypal figure, both superhuman and subhuman.

Weston goes from wimpering complainer to motiveless malignity, called the un-man, who Ransom, in good mythic fashion, defeats in a physical fight to save the Lady's innocence.

After defeating the un-man, Ransom makes his way to a high mountaintop of unimaginable beauty. After many days of healing, he meets with the Oyeresu of Malacandra and Perelandra, who take form in his presence as giant figure of Mars and Venus.

There he sees the Lady and her King, archetypal man and woman. He learns that they have been promoted by Maleldil to full power and rule over their planet.

Finally before returning to Earth, Ransom is given a prophecy of the end of earthly history and a vision of the eternal Reality, which Lewis presents as the Great Dance, in which "all the secular generalities of which history tells," the individual entities of nature, all personal beings, and even universal truths or qualities are revealed as "a whole solid figure" of enamoured and inter-inanimated circlings" and that figure in turn as the "mere superfiicers of a far vaster pattern in four dimensions".

Lewis takes too many measures to see to it that the reader cannot fail to entertain the similarity between the Perelandrian scenes and happenings as understood by orthodox Christianity. It is simply too much to have Ransom, about to hurl the stone into the Un-man's face say: "In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost, here goes--I mean Amen."

In this book, the Christian apologist definitely eclipsed the poet and artist.

THAT HIDEOUS STRENGTH: (1945)

In this final work of the space trilogy the fictional techniques of Charles Williams seem to have influence. This one takes place here on earth in a small college town of Edgestow. Elwin Ransom is again our hero.

Mark Studdock, a fellow at Bracton College as a socialologist, and his wife Jane are already having some marital problems after only 6 months. Mark receives an opportunity to take a leave from Bracton and join the staff of The National Institute of Coordinated Experiments or N.I.C.E. (which they are not).

Jane, because of bad dreams she is having, is advised to get involved with a group at St. Anne's on the Hill. These are the good guys/gals. She learns that there is a "company" at St. Anne's led by a mysterious Mr. Fisher King.

She finally does join them, and discovers Mr. Fisher King is really is a philologist, Ransom. He is here on Earth to combat a conspiracy against humankind. She is important to the company because her dreams are "true" and foretell the actions of the enemy, whose initials are N.I.C.E.

Meanwhile, Mark has finally been let in on what is happening at NICE. The goals are vast and utopian and totalitarian. It is literally run by a "Head", the severed head of Alcasan, an Arab radiologist executed for murder, kept "alive" by an ingenious mechanism.

N.I.C.E. wants Jane for her powers and put pressure on Mark to get her. When he fails, they imprison him and brainwash him. Thus NICE vs. St. Anne's Company with Merlin coming back to life and choosing to join Jane's group after 1500 years of sleep, because of Jane's dreams and Ransom's leadership.

Merlin effects the demise of NICE, creating nonsense in their words and loosing the animals they have kept caged for experiment. He helps Mark escape and all the NICE leaders are killed. Edgestow is destroyed by flood & Quake.

At St. Anne's, Ransom gives his farewell blessing to the company. The forces of evil have been thwarted for a time and he is returning to Venus. Mark and Jane are about to be reunited. Because of the change of heart he has undergone at Belbury and because of what the Director and the others at St. Anne's have taught her, the reader feels an assurance that the marriage has been set right.

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The influence of Williams can be seen not only in the handling of setting and character, but in the Arthurian materials which Lewis integrates with his own. Lewis underplays romantic love, which Williams would have made much of, and stresses instead--satirically--those factors in modern education and culture which are helping to drive Mark and Jane apart.

Lewis contrasts the differences between St. Anne's and Belbury to make his points. Both have gardens but the one at St. Anne's is natural, with animals free to roam. The one at Belbury is like the appearance of a municipal cemetery and the animals are caged.

The names of the people at NICE reveal Lewis' satirical intent. Names like Wither, Frost and Feverstone suggest blight and perversion. The good people have names like Dimble, Maggs and Denniston. It is, Lewis said, "a fairy tale for grown ups."

Other differences are that St. Anne's is openness, courtesy, good conversation, healthy domesticity and relationships while Belbury is secrecy, vagueness, uncertainty about one's status, perversion of the normal--an artificial life of neither laughter or tears.

NICE represents that fusion of state and laboratory on which so many thoughtful people base their hopes of a better world but actually is the kind of scientism that Lewis found an abomination.

The intentions of NICE were to "re-condition" all human beings, free the brain as much as possible from all that is organic, and take control of the destiny of mankind.

The story of Mark and Jane is a story of sin and repentance and regeneration. Sin understood as pride. Thru the healthful environment at St. Anne's Mark would be regenerated and healed.

In these three books, Mythically, we have moved from the unfallen creation of Malacandra through the temptation in the Eden of Perelandra to the arrogance of idolatrous civilization and the judgement of babel.

This battle between secular science and what Lewis sees as the Truth as a battle of Heaven and Hell, of Maleldil and the Bent Eldil. The blockade of the "silent planet" has been broken and the powers of Deep Heaven come down to empower Merlin, to save the world and to bring Mark and Jane together again.

That Hideous Strength is less successful then the other two for it attempts to much. The characters are 2 dimensional. If we concentrate on the moral satire, we can overlook somewhat the failure of good characterization.

Ransom changes to much in this novel, becoming an almost inhuman christ figure. He also is not very subtle about female submission. Women, it is clear, are supposed to live the traditional roles. For example, birth control in this book is made out to be a moral wrong.

The picture is somewhat confused because Lewis was a medievalist and felt that kings and nobility and the old fashioned ways were good in themselves while he attacks the aspects of modern life he disliked. One good quote to end with:

"Theology is talk--eyewash--a smoke screen--a game for rich men. It wasn't in the lecture rooms I found the Lord Jesus. It was in the coal pits, and beside the coffin of my daughter. If they think that theology is a sort of cotton wool which will keep them safe in the great and terrible day, they'll find their mistake."